AI And Machine Learning

How Marketers Can Adapt to LLM-Powered Search

by Stefano Puntoni, Mike Ensing and Jarvis Bowers

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Summary. Large language models (LLMs) provide a search experience that's dramatically different from the web-browser experience. The biggest difference is this: LLMs promise to answer queries not with links, as web browsers do, but with *answers*. Increasingly, using apps such as ChatGPT or Perplexity, or search portals such as Google's Search Generative Experience (now AI Overviews) or Bing's Copilot, customers will learn about products and brands through natural-language outputs. And that process, which will be highly consultative and conversational, will create a new information pipeline that marketers need to monitor to ensure their brands are presented for relevant prompts and described accurately. The authors present three ways for marketers to rise to this challenge. **close**

For millions of consumers around the world, Google is *the* access point to the internet — and as a result, the company today enjoys a 91% market share in the $50 billion market for search ads. However, thanks to the advent of large language models (LLMs), a shakeup now seems possible for the first time in two decades.

Why is that? Because LLMs provide a search experience that's dramatically different from the web-browser experience. The biggest difference is this: LLMs promise to answer queries not with links, as web browsers do, but with *answers*.

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To rise to this challenge, marketers will need to measure and monitor (1) whether their brands appear in LLM output, and when this is most likely to happen; (2) how favorably their brands are represented, and what negatives are attributed to their products; and (3) the visibility of their products and brands, as compared to their competition, across highly relevant prompts. Doing so will require marketers to not only test and develop relevant metrics but also develop new workflows to manage the added complexity.

A search for "best road bikes for beginners" highlights the new challenge. When we asked Perplexity, it recommended the Aventon Level 2 to us as the overall best beginner bike, citing relaxed geometry, wide tires, and quality components at a reasonable price. Google SGE, for its part, recommended the Giant Contend 3 or the Specialized Allez E5 to us. Both search experiences gave us guidance on what to consider when purchasing a new road bike and offered us an easy way to ask follow-up questions. But here's the most important thing: All of this took place before we were exposed to any brand's website. If an LLM doesn't mention your brand at this stage in the search process, users may never even consider it.

LLM Optimization

With new challenges come new opportunities. Just as the science of search engine optimization, or SEO, emerged during the era of browser-based searching, a new science of LLM optimization or LLMO, will now emerge — and marketers need to take advantage of it.

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The algorithms that power LLMs are not the same as traditional search algorithms. Google SGE operates on a different set of ranking factors than the traditional Google algorithm. The traditional search algorithm was optimized to promote links that were deemed authoritative, comprehensive, and relevant. Sites that prioritized metadata, keyword density, and backlinks garnered high rankings.

LLMs, however, are optimized to compile an accurate, compelling reply quickly. They pull content from multiple modalities (text, image, video) and multiple content types (reviews, brand site content, user-generated content) to create an answer. Accompanying users as they move from their initial query to follow-up questions, the LLM replies are all implicitly aware of where the user is in the buying process. Sites with content easily indexed by the LLM are therefore more likely to be cited within the response.

A crucial component of LLM search is known as retrieval-augmented generation, or RAG, whereby an LLM uses additional context, such as a set of company documents or web content, to augment its base model when responding to prompts. This has important implications for anybody hoping to engage in LLM optimization: If you want to alter the text produced by LLMs in response to a query, you need to think strategically about how to alter the various sources from which it is likely to pull information.

A new working paper by Harvard researchers demonstrates that the insertion of a "strategic text sequence" — text added to a product-information page to increase the chances of a product being recommended — can significantly alter the information provided by LLMs in response to a consumer's query. In their experiment, the Harvard team inserted a strategic text sequence to emphasize the affordability of a coffee machine, the ColdBrew Master, and significantly increased the likelihood that it would be mentioned by the LLM in response to a prompt asking for advice regarding affordable coffee machines. In the baseline scenario, the ColdBrew Master was never recommended by the LLM, but using their strategic text sequence, the researchers were able to turn it into the most frequently recommended product. (Another example of academic research discussing the optimization of web content for LLM-based search is here.)

We believe that LLMO will play a pivotal role in the evolution of new search experiences. Time will tell how Big Tech chooses to monetize

LLMs within their ecosystems. Some companies will choose a subscription model while others may choose ad monetization. Unlike today, though, where there is a dominant single player who controls much of the search experience online, we expect the future state to include multiple options for consumers to choose from. Which means that new job opportunities are likely to open up for people in the field of LLMO.

Jobs, Jobs, Jobs

Generative AI has been met with great anxiety among workers and policy makers because of its potential to displace millions of knowledge workers. Economists typically respond to such concerns by pointing out that past breakthrough innovations always resulted in more jobs and better jobs than we had before. The optimistic view on LLMs and jobs is that the same will happen this time.

It's true that in the years ahead, today's SEO specialists will find many of their current activities largely automated. LLMs have recently been proven more effective than human experts at the task of content optimization, and much cheaper too. We expect that in the future firms will be able to perform their SEO activities using a smaller number of employees, which naturally raises concerns about jobs.

But it is also true that the SEO role is becoming much more complex. SEO professionals — soon to be LLMO professionals — will need to manage brand representation across multiple LLM platforms, under a new set of optimization methodologies, and at a pace to keep up with the quickly evolving LLM landscape. Those SEO experts who are willing to continuously learn, adapt, and experiment with new techniques that raise visibility and favorability for their brands with LLMs will be in high demand. In short, they will become LLMO experts — a vitally important new role in companies and in the marketing-services firms that support them.

When a new powerful technology starts to affect the economy, people typically know which jobs are threatened but not which jobs will be created. Today, as in past technological revolutions, an important source of concern therefore lies in our limited ability to detect the shapes emerging on the horizon — the new jobs that will be created by LLMs. For marketing professionals, the shapes on the horizon are still blurry, but we can start seeing the outline of at least one.

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Stefano Puntoni is a professor of marketing at the University of Pennsylvania's Wharton